

Key points for input devices

Keyboards

One of the most important parts of a keyboard or mouse is the quality of materials used. This plays a major role in deciding its durability.

Membrane, mechanical, chiclet and hybrid are the common types of keyboards available currently. The difference is all about the switch type underneath the keys and the matrix or PCB underneath is almost the same in all of them. Membrane keyboards use a membrane between the keys and the circuit board. There are raised points near the keys and when they are pressed, they complete an electrical contact with the board and register the same key. They are quite basic and usually priced lower, and have lower durability since the membrane wears off.

Mechanical keyboards use an actual mechanical assembly to register your clicks while the underlying circuit board remains almost the same. Mechanical switches are made from mechanical parts which are more durable and can be easily identified because of the louder clicks. They are available in different flavours and by flavours we mean different travel distances, actuation points and feedback. The feedback or “feel” consists of



Backlights are gorgeous! A mechanical gaming keyboard with RGB backlighting.

essentially three types — linear, tactile and clicky. Cherry is the most popular mechanical switch manufacturers currently with knock off brands offering similar solutions at affordable prices. Because of high durability which is almost a life cycle of more than a decade for the switches, mechanical keyboards are expensive. There’s just too much to cover about mechanical switches and keyboards, and we have already dedicated many articles to them in the past, including a comparison test in the previous month.